

bills, and the company or the doctor or the hospital turns you over to a collection agency, your credit score will take a negative hit. Medical bills are aggressively pursued, and many doctors will not hesitate to turn you over to collections if you do not pay. This could bring down your credit score in a big way.

Believe me, when the topic of credit reports and credit scores comes up, I know some people are, shall we say, less than interested. Please remember that the lenders see you as a number, so you want to show the very best number possible. We have to get through this stuff before we can move on to the really good part. Your credit history is like the golden ticket that gets you into the candy factory. In this case, it is more like the money factory. Getting you out of debt and into wealth – I hope that holds your interest!

Most Americans don't know about this stuff, and that is why they fall victim to the system. It is up to us to spread the word. According to a July 2003 survey by the Consumer Federation of America, only two percent of Americans said they knew their credit score. And only three percent could name the three main credit bureaus.

Martin Luther King, Jr. once said, "The ultimate measure of a man is not where he stands in moments of comfort and convenience, but where he stands at times of challenge and controversy." Certainly facing a mountain of debt is a time of challenge. You and I may realize that the measure of a man, or a woman, can entail many facets, but as far as the lending industry is concerned, the only measure that matters to them is the credit score.